



USER GUIDE

# Competitor Guide

Everything you need to play a CTF on Flagpost

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For **Participants** · Flagpost **1.4.0-src** · 23 August 2026

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# Getting started

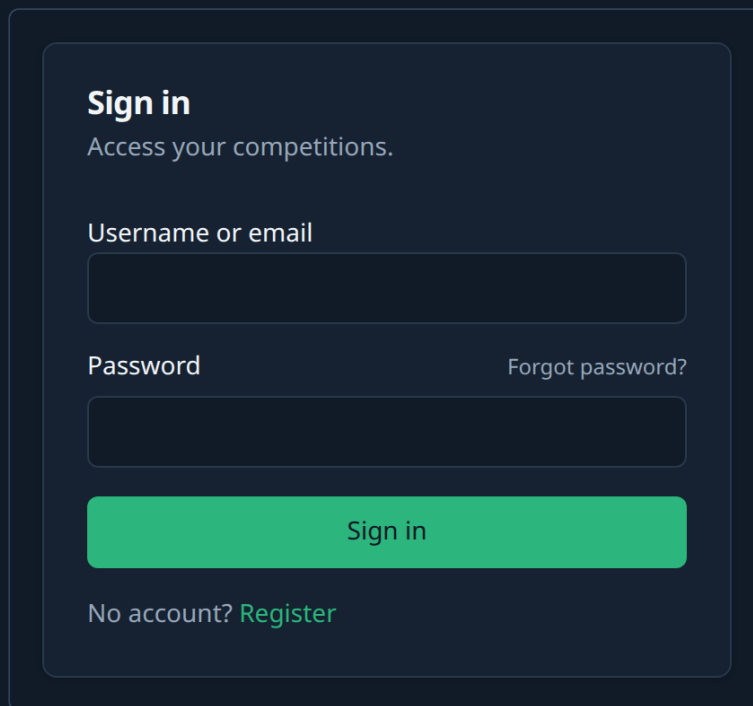
Flagpost is the platform your organisers use to run their capture-the-flag: it hosts the challenges, grades your flags, runs the scoreboard, and connects you with the event staff. This guide covers everything you need as a competitor — each chapter stands on its own when you need it mid-event.

## Your account

Your **username is your identity**: it's what you sign in with and what the scoreboard shows. An email address is optional unless your organisers require one — adding it lets you reset a forgotten password and receive email notifications.

Accounts arrive one of three ways: **register yourself** (if public registration is open — some sites restrict it to certain email domains or require verification), **sign in with an identity provider** (Google, Microsoft, GitHub, Discord, or your organisation's SSO — the account is created on first use), or **receive credentials** from the organisers.

## Signing in



**Sign in**  
Access your competitions.

Username or email

Password [Forgot password?](#)

[Sign in](#)

No account? [Register](#)

Sign in with your username or email — or any identity-provider button your site offers.

Forgotten password? Use **Forgot password** on the sign-in page (needs an email on file).

### ONE ACCOUNT, MANY EVENTS

Your account belongs to the site, not to one competition. When the next event runs on the same instance, sign in as usual and join it.

## Your profile

From the avatar menu you can set a **profile picture** (PNG, JPEG, or WebP — resized to a square for you, shown beside your name across the platform), change your **username** (the name you sign in with and appear as on the scoreboard — limited to once every 30 days), change your **password** or **email**, pick a personal **theme palette**, and manage **API tokens** if you use tooling that talks to Flagpost directly.

If you sign in before joining any competition you'll land in the **lobby** — the list of competitions you can join. That's chapter 2.

# Joining a competition

A Flagpost site can host many competitions, each with its own challenges, scoreboard, and teams. Switch between the ones you belong to with the selector in the top bar.

## Finding your competition

Open competitions appear in the lobby with a Join button. Invite-only competitions need an invite code from your organisers — enter it in the lobby's join by code field.

## Rules first

Many events ask you to **accept the rules** before you can play — and again if they change mid-event. Gameplay is blocked until you do. Read them: they're binding for prizes and conduct decisions.

## Individual or team mode

| MODE       | YOU COMPETE AS            | SCOREBOARD SHOWS |
|------------|---------------------------|------------------|
| Individual | yourself                  | players          |
| Team       | a team you create or join | teams            |

In a team competition you'll be prompted to **create a team** or **join one with a team code**. Teammates share solves, points, hints, and a private scratchpad on every challenge (chapter 5).

### BRACKETS

Some events split entrants into divisions — say, students and professionals. If yours does, you'll be placed in a bracket, the scoreboard can filter by it, and prizes are typically awarded within it.

## Start and finish

Joining early is normal. Until the organisers **start** the event, the challenges page shows a “hasn't started yet” notice — challenges and scoreboard open the moment it goes live. When the competition **ends**, submissions close automatically; the scoreboard and your history stay visible.

# Solving challenges

The **Challenges** page is where you'll spend the event.

**Challenges**  
Flagpost Demo CTF · 2 of 15 solved

[All 2/15](#)
[Crypto 0/4](#)
[Forensics 0/2](#)
[Misc 1/1](#)
[OSINT 0/1](#)
[Pwn 0/2](#)
[Reversing 0/2](#)
[Web 1/3](#)
[Cards](#)
[List](#)

| Category  | Challenge Title       | Difficulty | Tags                               | Points  | Solves   | Status |
|-----------|-----------------------|------------|------------------------------------|---------|----------|--------|
| Web       | Inspect the Source    | Easy       | beginner, web                      | 100 pts | 2 solves | Solved |
| Web       | Little Bobby Tables   | Medium     | web, sql                           | 250 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Web       | Reflected             | Hard       | web, xss                           | 300 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Crypto    | Base What?            | Easy       | crypto, base64                     | 150 pts | 1 solve  | Open   |
| Crypto    | Caesar's Secret       | Easy       | crypto                             | 200 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Crypto    | XOR-cism              | Medium     | crypto, xor                        | 300 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Crypto    | RSA Rookie            | Hard       | crypto, rsa                        | 450 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Pwn       | Warm Up               | Easy       | pwn, beginner                      | 500 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Pwn       | Ret2Win               | Medium     | pwn, buffer-overflow               | 400 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Reversing | Strings Attached      | Easy       | reversing, beginner                | 150 pts | 1 solve  | Open   |
| Reversing | Packed Lunch          | Medium     | reversing, unpacking               | 300 pts | 0 solves | Open   |
| Forensics | Hidden in Plain Sight | Easy       | forensics, steganography, metadata | 200 pts | 0 solves | Open   |

Cards grouped by category chips (each with your progress), showing points, difficulty and topic tags, live solve counts, and Solved/Open state. Prefer rows? Switch Cards → List — the choice sticks per device.

Two card states matter: **Locked** means the challenge has prerequisites — solve those first and it unlocks (opening it shows which). **Open** means it's ready. New challenges can appear mid-event in scheduled or manual waves — watch the announcements.

## Inside a challenge

The screenshot shows a challenge interface for 'Little Bobby Tables'. At the top, it says 'Web · 250 pts · 0 solves'. The description reads: 'The login form trusts its input a little too much. Can you make the database say more than it should?'. Below this is a 'Flag' section with a text input field containing 'flag{...}' and a green 'Submit flag' button. Underneath is a 'Solves' section stating 'No solves yet — be the first to solve it.'. The 'My notes' section describes a private scratchpad and includes a rich text editor with a toolbar (B, I, Code, List) and a 'Live' indicator.

The challenge view: description, flag entry, solves so far, and your private notes pad.

Depending on the challenge you'll also see **connection info** (where the live target runs, e.g. `nc chal.example.org 1337`, with a copy button), **attachments** to download, **hints** (chapter 4), and a presence line when others have the same challenge open.

## Submitting flags

Most challenges want a flag — usually `flag{...}` — pasted exactly as found: grading is precise, including case, unless the authors chose otherwise. A correct flag scores instantly, updates the scoreboard live, and marks the card solved; resubmitting a solved challenge never scores twice.

Some challenges are **multiple choice** instead. Two things to know:

- Your **guesses may be capped** — the challenge shows attempts remaining. Out of guesses? Open a support ticket; organisers can reset them.

- Events can enable a **wrong-guess penalty** that permanently reduces what that question is worth to you (or your team) with each wrong answer — the reduced value shows struck through next to the original.

#### PAUSED COMPETITIONS

Organisers can pause gameplay (say, during an infrastructure issue). A banner appears and submissions close until play resumes — everything else stays available.



# Hints, scoring & the scoreboard

## Hints

Hints may be free or **cost points** — the price shows up front, and revealing deducts it from your (or your team's) score, so agree before spending. Revealed hints stay visible all event, and organisers can release extra ones on a schedule as the competition unfolds.

## How points work

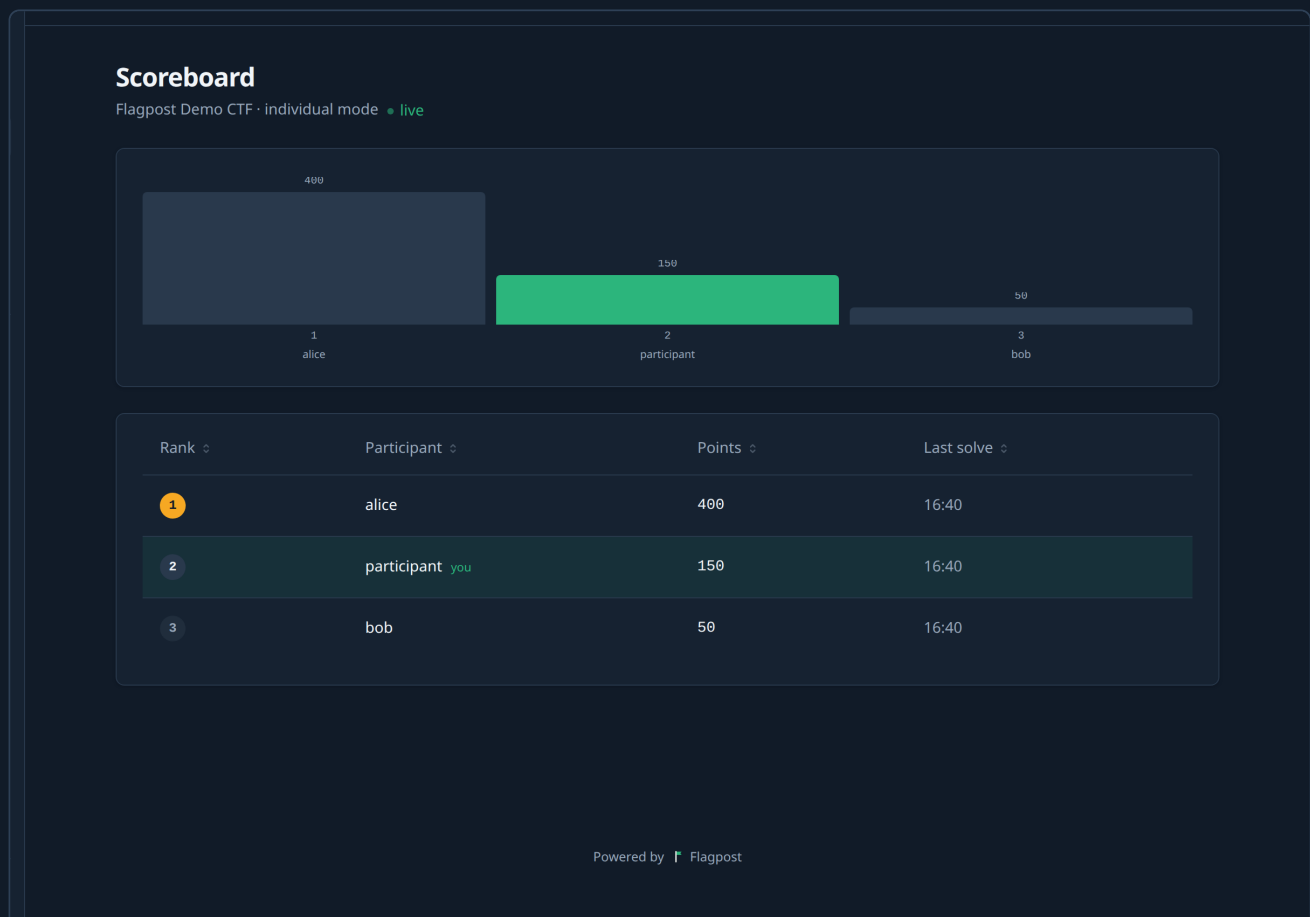
### SCHEME WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU

**Static** Fixed value — solve any time for the same points.

**Dynamic** The value **decays as more people solve it**, from a starting value toward a floor. Every solver holds the current value, first or last.

Dynamic scoring rewards hard challenges naturally: fewer solvers, higher worth — the card always shows the current value. **First blood** — the first solver — is marked on the challenge's solver list; some events attach prizes to it.

## The scoreboard



Live standings — your own row is highlighted. Click any entry for its solve history and points over time.

Ranking is by points, ties broken in favour of whoever got there first. If your event uses brackets, the board filters by division; some events also publish a **public spectator scoreboard** friends can watch without an account.

### SCOREBOARD FREEZES

Many events **freeze** the public board near the end to keep the finale suspenseful. Solves still count during the freeze — standings just stop updating publicly until the final reveal. Don't panic when a late solve doesn't appear to move you.

## Rating challenges

If feedback is enabled, a one-click rating prompt appears after each solve. Authors see aggregate ratings — it genuinely shapes future events.

# Playing as a team

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In team mode your team is the scoring unit: solves, points, hint costs, and guess caps are shared. (Individual players: the notes below work for you too — they're simply private to you.)

## Your team

Create a team when you join, or enter your team's **join code**. Any member's correct flag scores for the whole team, and their solve shows as solved for everyone — so split the categories and divide the board rather than double-working challenges. Team names appear on the scoreboard; pick one you're happy to see at the closing ceremony.

## Shared challenge notes

Every challenge carries a **notes scratchpad** — a live collaborative editor, private to your team, separate per challenge. Everyone can type at once, edits merge in real time, and notes persist all event. In individual mode the same pad is personal and syncs across your devices.

Use it as the team's memory: partial progress, working theories, payloads that almost worked. When someone rotates onto a challenge three hours in, the pad tells them everything that's been tried.

## Coordinating in practice

1. **Claim loudly** — put "I'm on this" at the top of the pad so two people don't burn the same hour.
2. **Dump progress as you go** — commands, endpoints, credentials, dead ends.
3. **Rotate stuck challenges** — fresh eyes beat tired ones; the pad makes hand-offs cheap.
4. **Watch the value** — on dynamic scoring, sometimes the winning move is to bank easier points first.

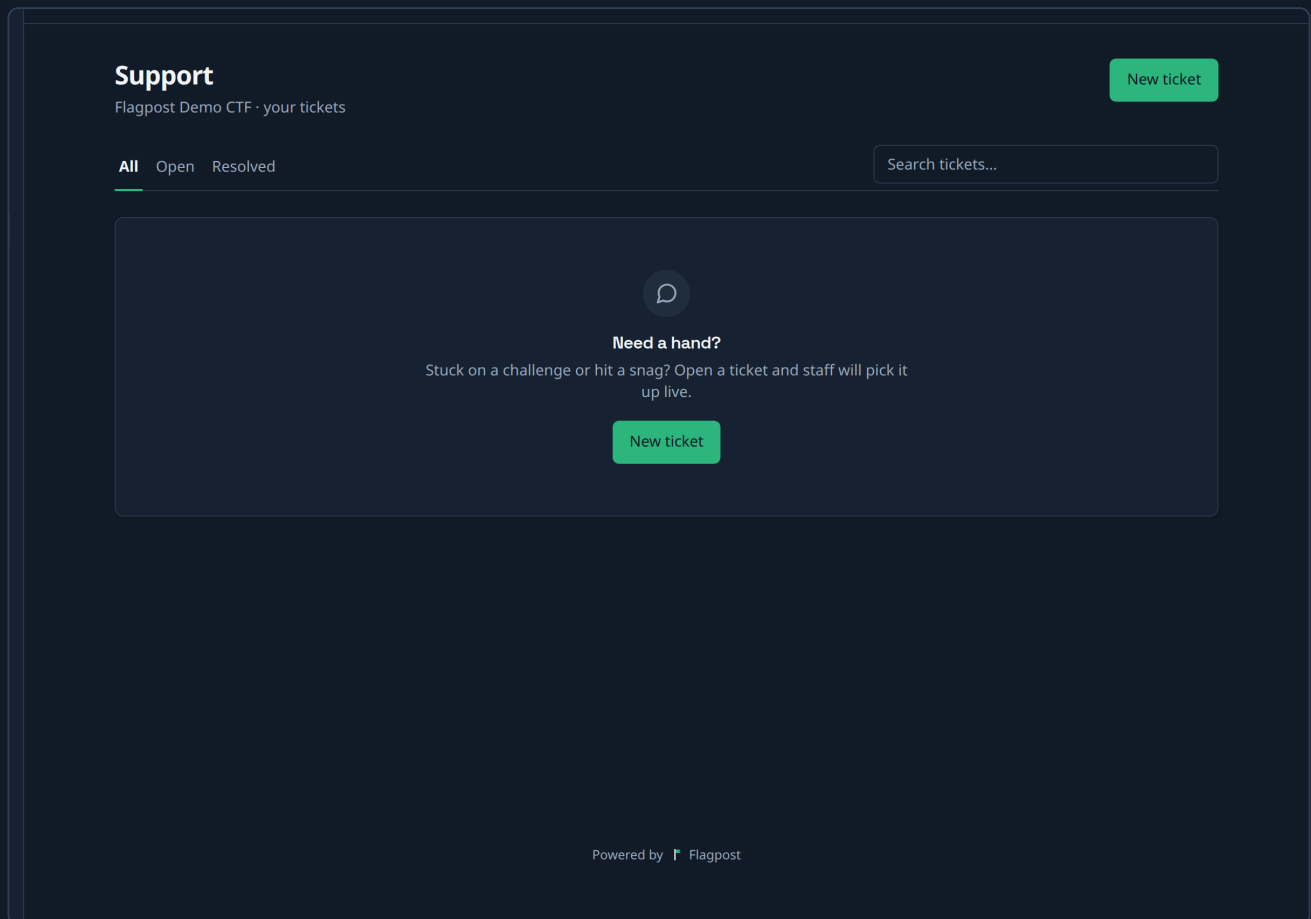
# Staying informed & getting help

## Announcements & notifications

Organisers broadcast **announcements** for anything event-wide — new challenge waves, hints, schedule changes. They arrive live as a banner, and the full history stays in the feed: glance at it after any break. The **bell** collects notifications addressed to you — ticket replies, team events — with an unread badge.

## Support tickets

When something's wrong — a target seems down, a sure flag is rejected, you're out of guesses, or you have a rules question — open a ticket from the **Support** page.



Each ticket is a live conversation with the organisers — replies appear in real time, and you're notified when they answer.

Name the challenge, say exactly what you tried, and keep one issue per ticket so each can be resolved cleanly.

### ASK EARLY

Judges would far rather field a quick “is this challenge behaving?” than have you lose an hour to a broken target. You may be the first to notice.

## Custom pages

Organisers often publish extra pages — full rules, prizes, venue or sponsor info. Look for them in the sidebar under the event's name.

## Conduct

The rules you accepted are the contract. The universal baseline: attack only the challenge infrastructure you're pointed at — never the platform or other competitors; don't share flags or solutions outside your team while the event runs; report anything that looks like an unintended shortcut. Organisers can see submission patterns — play it straight.

Good luck, and enjoy the event.

# FAQ

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## My flag is right but it was rejected — why?

Flags are graded exactly as submitted: full string, correct case (unless that challenge was authored case-insensitive), no stray whitespace, and the complete format — `flag{...}` wrappers included when shown. Paste rather than retype. Still stuck after checking those? Open a support ticket naming the challenge and what you submitted.

## A challenge was worth 500 — why is it 380 now?

That's **dynamic scoring**: the value decays as more people solve it, and every solver holds the current value. It can also be the **wrong-guess penalty** on a multiple-choice question — each wrong answer reduces what that question is worth to you or your team, shown struck through.

## I solved something but the scoreboard didn't move.

Near the end of an event the public board is often **frozen** — your solve counted the moment you submitted, and standings update at the reveal. Mid-event, remember the board ranks totals: a 100-point solve may not change your rank.

## Can I use Flagpost on my laptop and phone at once?

Yes — sign in on as many devices as you like. Your challenge notes sync live between them, so findings captured at the venue are on your laptop when you sit back down.

## What if I forget my password mid-event?

**Forgot password** on the sign-in page emails you a reset link — provided your account has an email address. Add one in your Profile now, before you need it.

## I'm out of guesses on a multiple-choice question.

Open a support ticket. Organisers can restore attempts for you or your team — it's non-destructive, so nothing about your history is lost.

## Who can read my challenge notes?

Your team, and only your team — each challenge's pad is private to the team it belongs to (in individual mode, private to you). Write freely.

## Can my tools talk to Flagpost directly?

Yes — create a personal **API token** in your Profile and use it from scripts or clients. Tokens act as you, so treat them like your password and delete any you stop using.